

React Rinse Repeat

With election fever in the air, everyone around me has turned into a sooth-sayer. Every chai time conversation, every street corner debate, every WhatsApp group chat seems to be about just one thing – who will win the elections? As I write this editorial contemplating my own vote the next day, I feel the need to take a break and move on to lighter, more familiar topics of prediction. Specifically, predictions about technology.

If you were asked to look into your own personal crystal ball and come up with a list of things that you foresee in the future, what would you envision? Flying cars? Robot servants to do your bidding? Best selling novels written by algorithms? As it turns out, the Pew Research Center recently surveyed Americans from all walks of life asking them to do exactly that. Participants were queried on a wide range of potential scientific developments – from near-term advances like drones and wearable technology, to more futuristic possibilities like teleportation or space colonisation.

A peculiar finding emerged. While people were overwhelmingly convinced that a tech-dominated, sci-fi future awaits them, as with politics, not everyone was too sure about the outcome of these changes. Specifically, they weren't sure whether the choices they make or the direction which technology takes mankind would be good or bad. For example, 66 per cent thought it would be a change for the worse if prospective parents could alter the DNA of their children to produce smarter, healthier or more athletic offspring.

But what about near-term predictions about technology? Recently, a company called Frog Design – an industrial design outfit – made quite a few predictions, three of which caught my attention. The first is that anonymity will go mainstream. This one's pretty easy to plot considering what we've learnt from the Snowden leaks, Heartbleed bug and other recent privacy debacles. If things like Snapchat, the self-destructing Boeing Black phone and John McAfee's NSA-proof DCentral device are indicators of what's to come, this one's a certainty. Frog Design says that 2014 will see an influx of platforms catering to a digital experience grounded in anonymity.

The second prediction is about on-demand services. A relatively nondescript start-up in San Francisco called Uber has been making waves recently and was at some point hyped by analysts as an entity that's going to become bigger than Face-

book. What's Uber? Well, it's like Meru Cabs on steroids. Frog believes that this "on-demand" model will soon extend across other personal services, not just personal transportation. From home maintenance to dog walking and everything in between, we'll have apps that will connect us to service providers in an instant. Say you need an electrician. A few taps on your smartphone and it tells you a handyman is on his way, only three minutes away.

The last prediction is something I'd spoken about in last month's editorial – a shift towards disconnecting from technology. A section of the population is slowly realising that experiencing life through a four-inch screen isn't all that great. Artists have already started asking concert goers to stop recording their shows and actually experience the moment. Pretty soon, people will set up "dark zones" in their houses that will allow you to sink into a chair, web-free and just think! Who knows, cinema halls might even use network jammers (one can only dream).

The curious thing about these predictions is that they show a tendency of technology coming full circle. Remember back when people first started getting online, they'd take pains to remain as anonymous as possible? We'd have usernames like orbitalenergy@hotmail.com with no personally identifiable data voluntarily proffered. (That account still exists, and no prizes for guessing who it belongs to.) Soon, web giants started pushing people to enter their real names and now you have a reversal towards anonymity.

Back in the day when you wanted something done, a list of service provider numbers noted somewhere was all you had. You didn't have an app to call a chauffeur, but knew how to reach one (Yellow Pages, anyone?). The last prediction – the unplugging movement – brings to mind the era when Television started invading dinner time conversation. Soon it was deemed bad manners and the TV was relegated back to the living room from the kitchen. But for a while, people were struggling and learning to adapt to this new technology. That's the beauty of it. Tech evolves and we evolve to adapt to it. The only constant we can bank on is its tendency to eventually come full circle. 



Siddharth Parwatay
Assistant Editor

siddharth.parwatay@thinkdigit.com

"The curious thing about these predictions is that they show a tendency of technology coming full circle"

Got feedback about this column?
Drop me a line at:
siddharth.parwatay@thinkdigit.com